

YOU HAVE
ONLY 2 MOVES

IQ: 155



TDV

STARTUPS



Uzbekistan's first unicorn,
Uzum, leaps to a \$1.5B
valuation



At a time when the world feels increasingly divided between East and West, Uzbekistan has emerged as a rare middle ground, as the Central Asian nation's homegrown unicorn, [Uzum](#), has raised \$65.5 million in a new funding round co-led by China's Tencent and the New York- and London-based VR Capital, with participation from U.S.-based FinSight Ventures.

The all-equity round brings the Tashkent-headquartered startup's post-money valuation to approximately \$1.5 billion — a nearly 30% jump from the \$1.16 billion valuation it announced when it [first hit unicorn status](#) in March last year.

Founded in 2022, Uzum started its journey in Uzbekistan with an e-commerce marketplace called Uzum Market, and shortly after its success, the startup added fintech with a debit card and later expanded into its express food delivery service, Uzum Tezkor.

Uzum currently boasts over 17 million monthly active users — nearly half of Uzbekistan's adult population, or about two-thirds of all smartphone users in the country — and 16,000 merchants. In the first half of 2025 alone, the startup recorded \$250 million in gross merchandise value (GMV), up nearly 1.5x year-over-year.

Its digital banking arm, Uzum Bank, launched a co-branded Visa debit card with pre-approved credit limits in August last year. That product has already issued 2 million cards and is on track to surpass 5 million by year-end. Meanwhile, Uzum's unsecured lending business hit \$200 million in financed volume in Q1, growing 3.4x from the same period last year. The startup also [posted](#) \$150 million in net income in 2024 — a 50% year-over-year jump.

With a portfolio spanning e-commerce, fintech, and digital banking, how has a startup just over three years old managed to scale this quickly — and draw the attention of global investors like Tencent?

Uzum founder and CEO Djasur Djumaev attributes the success to a combination of deep local knowledge and disciplined execution. He believes that understanding the

DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

country's culture, consumer behavior, and business environment — and pairing that with the technical and operational expertise that global companies have developed — has been critical to building a business that can scale quickly and sustainably.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

The startup built its digital and physical infrastructure from scratch to kick off its business in Uzbekistan. This includes setting a logistics capacity that has grown to 112,000 square meters, with a storage capacity of 1.1 million square feet, allowing it to process more than 200,000 orders per day.

The startup has also set up more than 1,500 pickup points across 450 cities, towns, settlements, and villages in the country to enable next-day deliveries. These pickup points also allow the issuance and distribution of Uzum Bank cards.

“Betting on local expertise and infrastructure in frontier markets gives you an advantage to then perform and scale your business very fast,” Djumaev told TechCrunch in an exclusive interview.



UZUM'S PICKUP POINT.

IMAGE CREDITS:UZUM

Initially, Uzum operated on a fulfilled-by-operator model to enable e-commerce deliveries. It has since expanded to include fulfillment-by-seller and delivery-by-seller options, with a goal of routing 20% to 30% of deliveries through these new models. These new delivery models will also help Uzum expand its stock-keeping units, which are currently over 1.5 million available for its next-day delivery service, up from over 600,000 SKUs at the time of its last funding announcement in March 2024.

When asked what brought Tencent onto its cap table this time, Uzum's chief strategy and business development officer, Nikolay Seleznev, told TechCrunch the startup's strong growth metrics convinced the Chinese investor to come on board after several quarters of ongoing discussions.

Uzum plans to grow its fintech business by introducing a deposit product in September and a long-term (more than 12 months in maturity) credit facility for its B2C customers. The startup also plans to expand its merchant base and help its existing and new merchants with its QR code payment processing system, expand its Visa debit card program, and build new products to support small and medium enterprises in the country.

Similarly, the startup plans to introduce new products adding value-added services to its e-commerce business, including those helping to generate advertisement revenues. It is also working toward scaling its financial infrastructure further with AI increasingly embedded across credit scoring, fraud protection, and personalized user experiences.

Furthermore, Uzum plans to open up its e-commerce marketplace for international merchants, beginning with those in China and Turkey in September.

“We are expecting 10 to 15% of cross-border activity coming from these countries,” Seleznev said.

The startup has over 12,000 people in its workforce, including blue-collar workers at its pickup points, as well as tech, engineering, and product teams across all its business verticals.

Similar to other businesses of its sort, which are profitable and have multiple avenues to generate continuous income over time, Uzum has plans to become public in the medium term. But before that, it aims to raise a Series B round of \$250–\$300 million in the first half of 2026.

That said, the startup has so far raised \$137 million in equity, including the latest round.

Topics: [Asia](#) [Commerce](#) [e-commerce](#) [Fintech](#) [Startups](#)

[Tencent](#) [Uzbekistan](#) [Uzum](#) [VR Capital](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [reddit](#) [email](#) [link](#)



Jagmeet Singh

Reporter | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [reddit](#) [email](#) [link](#)



A private equity bet in Latin America proves the strength of fintech investments there

Jonathan Shieber — 11:49 AM PST · January 22, 2019

Latin America is getting another fintech unicorn thanks to Advent International's acquisition of a 51 percent stake of [Prisma Medios de Pago](#), an Argentine payments company formed as a joint venture between Visa International and local banks.

IMAGE CREDITS: [STUART KINLOUGH](#)

The deal, which values Prisma at \$1.42 billion, is yet another sign of Latin America's growing prominence for global investment and the central role that fintech plays in the development of an innovation economy in the region.

Prisma Medios de Pago is the leading payments company in Argentina, and one of the largest in Latin America, with a full suite of services including point-of-sale hardware rental, e-commerce gateways, transaction processing, payments processing and electronic bill pay.

Its newest business line, TodoPago, offers peer-to-peer payments, mobile wallets, point of sale offerings, QR code payments and e-commerce payments to merchants.

Across Latin America, fintech startups have hit billion-dollar valuations and raised hundreds of millions as investors vie for a piece of the region's growing e-commerce and financial services markets.

Advertisement

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

Brazil's StoneCo Ltd., a provider of payment technology and services, is worth more than \$6 billion after its October 2019 initial public offering. It's a decline from the \$9 billion pop the company had back when it debuted on the Nasdaq, but still represents a healthy valuation for the Latin American technology company.

Waiting in the wings are companies like Brazil's NuBank, [which reached a \\$4 billion valuation](#) last year on the strength of a significant investment from the Chinese technology giant, Tencent.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

TechCrunch Week in Review

Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility

TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



Advertisement

Nubank is now worth \$4 billion after Tencent's \$180 million investment



Nubank, the Brazilian financial services company, has raised \$180 million from the Chinese internet giant, Tencent. Tencent has long been interested in financial services startups, and with its \$90 million direct investment and another \$90 million investment in the secondary market, the company now has access to what is arguably the largest digital

banking company ... [Continue reading](#)

At the time, company co-founders Cristina Junqueira and David Velez said the opportunity for financial services startups to achieve significant scale was far higher in emerging markets like Brazil than in developed markets, because the barriers to banking are so much higher.

Financial services, Velez said, has been controlled by massive oligopolies that have erected unfair obstacles to wealth creation for the masses. Nubank and other companies like it are working to change that.

An article [from Fintech Futures](#) last year outlined just how large the opportunity was for Latin America. In 2018, roughly half the population of Latin America was unbanked. In Brazil, about 40 percent of the country have no access to traditional banking services and its small businesses face a credit gap of \$237 billion, according to a McKinsey study cited by Fintech Futures.

Investment in fintech has soared alongside the opportunity. Two years ago, fintech investment on the continent nearly hit \$600 million, and public offerings like Stone and PagSeguro point to public market appetite for the sector.

Topics: [Argentina](#) [Banking](#) [Brazil](#) [David Velez](#) [e-commerce](#)

[economy](#) [finance](#) [latin america](#) [money](#) [nubank](#)

[payments processing](#) [Startups](#) [technology](#) [Tencent](#)

Advertisement



Jonathan Shieber

Writer | [X](#)

Jonathan was an editor at TechCrunch./p>

[View Bio](#) >



IMAGE CREDITS: UZUM

COMMERCE



Meet Uzbekistan's first unicorn: e-commerce startup Uzum

Jagmeet Singh — 10:00 PM PDT · March 25, 2024

[Uzum](#), an e-commerce startup offering online shopping, fintech and food deliveries to millions of customers in Uzbekistan, has raised \$114 million in funding, becoming the country's first unicorn with a valuation of \$1.16 billion.

Uzbekistan is fertile ground for startups, given the fact that people aged below 30 constitute [about 60% of its population of over 35 million](#). The country also enjoys [a near 100% literacy rate](#) (according to its government), [more than 76% internet penetration](#), and [over 75% smartphone penetration rate](#). In 2020, the Central Asian nation had nearly 1,200 startups, 85% of which were at the seed stage. Fintech startups dominated the market with a 30% share, followed by e-commerce startups at 27%, according to [estimates](#) (PDF) by the Asian Development Bank.

Advertisement

Latest in Commerce

See More

Latest

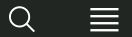
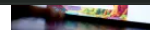
Security

Startups

AI

Venture

Apps

[Events](#)[Podcasts](#)[Newsletters](#)[Djumaev told TechCrunch](#)

Sarah Perez - Jul 28, 2025

Djumaev clearly saw the potential for a company to do in Uzbekistan what Amazon has done in a lot of other countries: offer a cohesive marketplace that promises end-to-end logistics and delivery. Uzum started by setting up its logistics, a fleet, and established pickup points to offer next-day deliveries. The marketplace was launched in October 2022, and today, it has more than 8 million monthly active users and over 9,000 merchants selling 600,000+ SKUs. In contrast, the biggest street bazaar in the country has about 70,000 SKUs on any given day, according to Nikolay Seleznev, chief strategy and business development officer at Uzum. In its first full year of operations, the startup recorded gross merchandise value (GMV) of \$150 million and expects run-rate GMV to reach at least \$300 million this year.

Shortly after its success with the marketplace, Uzum forayed into fintech with a buy now, pay later (BNPL) product. About 45% to 50% of its e-commerce transactions are done via the BNPL solution, Djumaev said. Uzum has also entered the food delivery business and set up a digital bank to bolster its growth.

“Because we attract customers on e-commerce, we retain them on high-transaction businesses like daily banking, which is 100% digital. We monetize them on our lending or credit products, which are 100% Sharia-compliant, which is also very appealing to at least 85% of the population in Uzbekistan,” Seleznev told TechCrunch.

Advertisement



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt

2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

The Series A round, comprising \$52 million in equity and the remaining \$62 million in debt, was led by FinSight Ventures and saw participation from Xanara Investment Management and Uzum's senior management. Uzum has diluted less than 5% to investors participating in the Series A round, which is the startup's first external funding. The startup also plans to raise about \$200 million in a Series B round this year from investors in the Middle East, U.K. and the U.S.

Uzum plans to use two-thirds of the fresh funding for its fintech business and one-third for the e-commerce arm. There are plans to launch new products for unsecured lending to individuals as well as small- and medium-sized enterprises and invest in its own IT and logistics infrastructure.

"We want to expand the products, enhance the infrastructure of our e-commerce, and fund our fintech," Djumaev said.

Seleznev said the startup intends to expand its GMV by 150% to 200%, grow its credit portfolio at least two times, and increase the total payment volume circulated through its ecosystem.

By the end of this year, Uzum plans to combine all its businesses into two super apps: one for its consumer-focused offerings and another for its business-focused products. It also aims to launch the country's "largest" logistics complex for e-commerce in June, planned to span 112,000 square meters initially, and expanded to over 500,000 square meters in the next few years.

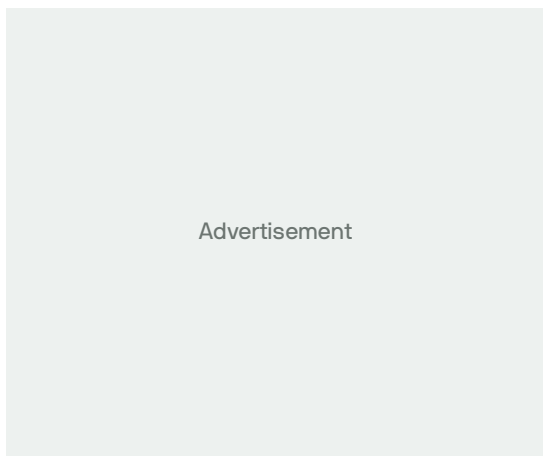
Djumaev said a few companies globally operate similarly to Uzum and named Latin America's Nubank and Kazakhstan's Kaspi.kz. However, he doesn't see any competition in

Uzbekistan, as Uzum has the advantage of enjoying different margins across products and can make higher margins by combining its e-commerce and fintech services.

“We witnessed the success of Kaspi.kz in creating a super app in neighboring Kazakhstan, and we are confident that Uzum, which has the necessary talent, resources and products, will repeat this success to become a national tech leader in Uzbekistan,” said Alexey Garyunov, managing partner of FinSight Ventures, in a prepared statement.

Topics: [Asia](#) [Commerce](#) [e-commerce](#) [Exclusive](#)

[FinSight Ventures](#) [Startups](#) [unicorn](#) [Uzum](#)



[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [t](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



Jagmeet Singh

Reporter | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————



India's Udaan raises \$585M to expand its B2B e-commerce platform

Manish Singh — 10:16 AM PDT · October 2, 2019

Udaan, a three-year-old business-to-business e-commerce platform in India, has raised more than half a billion dollars in a new financing round as it looks to bring more kirana stores (neighborhood stores), chemists and other small businesses online through its marketplace.

The startup said today it has raised \$585 million in a Series D round from Tencent, Altimeter, Footpath Ventures, Hillhouse, GGV Capital and Citi Ventures. Existing investors Lightspeed Venture Partners, which wrote its first check to the startup back in 2016, and DST Global also invested in the round.

The new round — the largest for any B2B e-commerce platform in India — valued the startup between \$2.3 billion and \$2.7 billion, a person familiar with the matter told TechCrunch. Co-founders of Udaan, which reached the unicorn status in the shortest period of time among Indian startups, declined to comment on the valuation.

Udaan operates an eponymous B2B marketplace that connects small retailers with wholesalers and traders. The platform supports a wide-range of categories from lifestyle, electronics, home and kitchen, staples and toys, to fruits and vegetables.

Advertisement

DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

**Most
Popular**



Udaan also offers a credit line to provide working capital to buyers and sellers on its platform, thereby addressing one of the biggest challenges faced by small and micro businesses and merchants in the nation, said Vaibhav Gupta, a co-founder of Udaan, in an interview with TechCrunch. The credit to buyers and sellers is financed by Udaan and other non-banking partners, he said.

The startup has amassed more than 3 million retailers and more than 25,000 sellers from 900 cities and towns in India. The startup processed five million orders in the month of August.

Today, a wide range of merchants, including farmers, shopkeeper owners, restaurants, chemists and street vendors are connected to Udaan. The startup has set up a supply chain network throughout the nation to fulfill more than half of the orders on its platform.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion
- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

Advertisement



FROM LEFT-TO-RIGHT: AMOD-MALVIYA, VAIBHAV GUPTA AND SUJEET KUMAR, CO-FOUNDERS OF UDAAN

Sujeet Kumar, another co-founder of Udaan, said the startup will use the fresh capital to expand its supply chain network in the nation and focus on growing the marketplace in both existing and new categories. The startup will also look to scale UdaanCapital, its credit line business.

Even as more than half a billion people in India are online today, most businesses in the nation remain offline. But a growing [cohort of startups](#) in the nation is beginning to help merchants make use of technology.

Amazon and Walmart have invested billions of dollars to create business-to-commerce marketplaces in India, but e-commerce still accounts for just 3% of the overall retail market in the country.

Their mightiest rivals remain mom and pop stores that dot tens of thousands of villages, cities, towns and slums of India. In recent years, many Silicon Valley companies have also started to address these businesses. Google has launched tools to help these mom and pop stores set up their online presence, and, last month, it launched a [business app of Google Pay](#) to help these merchants accept online payments.

That's the opportunity that drove Vaibhav, Sujeet and Amod Malviya — the third co-founder — to [leave their jobs at e-commerce platform Flipkart](#) and build a platform to serve small businesses in the nation.

“The market opportunity is turning out to be much deeper than we envisioned when Lightspeed led the company's

Series A financing in 2016 and we're excited to continue supporting the company while welcoming a strong syndicate of new investors," said Bejul Somaia, a partner at Lightspeed Venture Partners.

In a statement, Martin Lau, president of Tencent, said, "Udaan's unique approach can enhance the capabilities of millions of retail stores across India. It represents a powerful example of how technology can empower the business of small merchants, improve the efficiency of industries and bring benefits to consumers."

As Udaan scales its business, the startup will explore ways to generate more revenue, Gupta said. "We have barely scratched the surface, so our focus largely has been to bring more businesses onto the platform and build products and services to serve their needs. That said, monetization is something that we are looking at as our business grows. We are taking calculated measures to generate revenue from the aspect of our business that is maturing," he added.

Udaan, which in recent quarters has introduced features such as support for government-backed UPI payments platform and an easy tax invoicing tool, expects to clock about \$2 billion in annual GMV this year.

[A 23-year-old B2B company has shown how keen India is for tech IPOs](#)

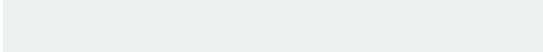
Topics: [Amazon](#) [Asia](#) [DST Global](#) [Fintech](#) [Flipkart](#)

[ggv capital](#) [Google](#) [India](#) [lightspeed venture partners](#)

[logistics](#) [Media & Entertainment](#) [Startups](#) [Tencent](#)

[Udaan](#)

Advertisement



Manish Singh

Reporter, India | [X](#) [in](#)

Manish Singh is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, covering India’s startup scene and venture capital investments. He also reports on...

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article

